TACTICAL RECONNAISSANCE: MLH Midnight Hackathon (May 15–17, 2026)

Prepared for: Stephen Sookra · Solo build · SafePassage on Midnight (DeFi Track + Top 2 Overall play) Cutoff: May 14, 2026 evening ET

> **Sourcing note.** Confirmed facts are sourced inline. Items derived from inference are flagged "[inference]"; items in the user's task brief that I could not corroborate during this research session are flagged "[unverified — user-provided]" and should be re-checked Thursday before trusting them in conversation with judges. Specifically: the user task brief listed both "Eran Barak (Midnight CEO)" and "Mike Ward (CEO Shielded Technologies)" / "Bob Blessing-Hartley (CTO)"; my primary sources (Cointelegraph, Cryptobitmag, Blockleaders, Authority Magazine) consistently identify **Eran Barak as CEO of Shielded Technologies / the Midnight initiative at IOG, and Ben Beckmann as CTO of Shielded Technologies**. The Ward/Blessing-Hartley names may be older or parallel roles — flagged unverified.

---

1) PAST MIDNIGHT HACKATHON WINNERS ANALYSIS

The full Midnight hackathon ladder, Aug 2024 → Nov 2025:

- **Virtual Hackathon (Aug 19 – Sep 13, 2024)** — first ever. Judged by Midnight product & DevRel against five criteria: technology, innovation, completion, real-life application, and developer-experience feedback (midnight.network/blog/virtual-hackathon-winners). Midnight
  - 1st: **Erick Romero** (later lead of Edda Labs).
  - 2nd: **Krish Dhar's team — "ZK Uno"** — zero-knowledge card game. Judges highlighted "refined presentation and functional game." Midnight
  - 3rd: **John Santi — "DIDz Identity"** — decentralized identity. Won on "clear vision for real-world applications" via video. Midnight
- **Cardano Tech Week, Buenos Aires (Dec 2024)** — ~60 participants, half built on Midnight. Theme: governance (midnight.network/blog/hackathon-winners-cardano-tech-week). Midnight
  - 1st: **TxPipe** — DAO voting system. Midnight
  - 2nd: **Edda Labs (Erick Romero)** — private voting feature integrated with Mesh Multi-sig. Midnight
  - 3rd / standout: **Protofire** — identity voting DApp, dual-tracked Cardano + Midnight. Midnight
- **Mini Dapp Hackathon (mid-2025)** — closest archetype to Stephen's DeFi track build.

    - 1st: **LucentLabs** — private overcollateralized stablecoin protocol for institutional use, featuring **shielded liquidations** and **off-chain identity verification for compliance**. Midnight
    - **Midnight Bank** — confidential banking DApp with private transfers and multi-party transaction authorization. Midnight
    - **zkBadge** — verifiable credentials (e.g., age verification) without exposing personal data; trusted-issuer model. Midnight
- **Buenos Aires Mini Dapp Hackathon (later 2025)** — 16 teams / ~70 hackers / ~200 panel attendees (midnight.network/blog/state-of-the-network-september-2025). Midnight
    - **Blockenfy** (privacy-preserving KYC), **Gracias Esteban** (RWA tokenization into confidential digital shares), **Raccoons** (private sealed-bid auctions). Midnight
- **Ecosystem Tooling Challenge** (DEV.to-hosted, Sep 2025). Winners: **Bochaco, CardanoProphet, IslandGhostStephanie** — awarded Zealy XP + branded prizes for shipping a React wallet-connect guide, Cargo Clippy fixes, and updates to Midnight Docs / Midnight JS (midnight.network/blog/state-of-the-network-november-2025). Tooling-track winners shipped *boring infrastructure fixes*, not new dApps. **Scaffold Midnight** [unverified — user-provided] and **Midnight MCP / Compact Agent Skill** (forum.midnight.network/t/.../1083) belong to this category: developer-tooling artifacts that the Midnight team explicitly rewards and that the Compact Agent Skill is now an *officially endorsed* AI tooling output. Midnight Midnight Network
- **DEGA Virtual Hackathon — "AI for DAO Treasury Management on Midnight"** (registration Sept 2025, payout in $USDM Nov 2025, $8K pool) (dorahacks.io/hackathon/ai-treasury-management/detail). Privacy-first AI tooling for DAO treasuries. DoraHacks
- **MLH × Midnight Hackathon — Sep 26–28, 2025** (events.mlh.io/events/12829; midnight-hackathon.devpost.com) — the "successful hackathon in the fall" cited on the May 2026 event page. Top-4-per-track prize: **10-week MLH Fellowship incubator + free pass and travel grant to Midnight Summit London + headphones + swag bag.** Devpost judging criteria displayed: **Technology, Originality, Execution** (+ 1). Best Beginner = >50% first-time hackers. Midnight Hackathon + 2
- **Midnight Summit Hackathon, London — Nov 17–19, 2025** — largest Midnight in-person event ever (450+ Summit attendees, 120+ on-site hackers + remote, $25K total prize pool). Four tracks: **AI, Healthcare, Governance & Identity, Finance.** Format: GitHub repo initial submission Nov 18; final Nov 19; top 4 per track (16 teams total) selected to pitch live; **5 Build Club seats** awarded — 1 Top Overall + 1 Runner-up in same track + 3 other track winners + 1 community vote (midnight.network/blog/everything-you-need-to-know-for-the-2025-midnight-summit-hackathon). Midnight + 4
- **Hackabull 2025 (USF, April 12–13, 2025)** — 300+ student MLH event with Midnight as a side prize (wireless headphones for "Best Midnight DApp"). Not Midnight-dominant (usf.edu/business/news/2025/hackabull2025.aspx). University of South Florida Hackabull 2025

Recurring winning fingerprint:

1. Compiled, deployed Compact contract demoable on testnet/preview.
2. A privacy-specific *threat model* clearly stated in the video ("X data, leaked to Y party, causes Z harm").
3. Concrete user/institutional persona (KYC for an exchange, voting for a DAO, lending for a fund).
4. Selective-disclosure framing — explicit acknowledgement that data is *shared with authorized parties* when needed.
5. Tight ⩽2-minute demo with a working transaction shown end-to-end.

Recurring losing fingerprint:

- Generic "private version of [X]" with no story for who is harmed without privacy.
- Submissions where the proof server / Lace integration didn't work at demo time.
- Over-ambitious cryptographic constructions that didn't compile by submission.
- Projects positioned as Zcash-style "everything is secret" — collides with the team's "rational privacy / selective disclosure" framing.

TACTICAL IMPLICATION FOR SAFEPASSAGE: The LucentLabs/Midnight Bank/Gracias Esteban template is the blueprint to imitate — a financial primitive + a compliance/disclosure hook + a named institutional partner persona (DV services org, state crime-victim compensation fund). Win condition: "deployable Compact contract + 90-second demo video showing the disbursement flow + a single sentence that names the survivor *and* the auditor who can see what they need to see."

---

2) MIDNIGHT TEAM / LIKELY JUDGES INTELLIGENCE

Confirmed leadership:

- **Eran Barak** — CEO, Shielded Technologies / "CEO of the Midnight initiative at Input Output" (cointelegraph.com/news/onchain-privacy-necessity-age-ai-shielded-ceo; cryptobitmag.com/midnight-network-interview-permissionless-iii). Highest-value quote bank for evaluator priorities: Cryptobitmag
    - **"Privacy isn't a luxury in crypto, it's a necessity"** (cointelegraph.com/news/privacy-isn-t-luxury-crypto-necessity-midnight-ceo).
    - **"Metadata reveals much about an individual or entity that allows them to be easily identified, traced, and modeled by threat actors."** Cointelegraph

    - The recurring **medical-records example**: "the frequency of visits to a doctor could signal that something is wrong to any outside observer." Cointelegraph
    - **"We protect the patterns as well as the data — because AI learns just as much from how you act as what you say."** — Consensus 2025 panel (blockleaders.io/spotlight-on-midnight-charles-hoskinson-leads-the-call-for-rational-privacy-in-web3-2/). Blockleaders
    - **"No enterprise in their right mind is going to deploy dApps in the public sphere; they have to be protected."** (TapTools). Medium
    - Background: built Hexadite (sold to Microsoft), led MIND DLP/IRM, Israeli Defence Forces Tech Intel (medium.com/authority-magazine/data-privacy-eran-barak-of-mind...). Medium
- **Charles Hoskinson** — IOG CEO / Cardano founder. Likely keynote-only. Consensus 2025 one-word North Star: **"Fairness."** Eran's was **"Metadata."** Fahmi Syed's was **"Adoption — real apps, real users, real-world impact."** Blockleaders Blockleaders
- **Fahmi Syed** — President, Midnight Foundation. Adoption-focused. Most predictive single voice for Build Club selection.
- **Ben Beckmann** — CTO, Shielded Technologies (blockleaders.io article; also spelled "Beckman"). On Consensus panel: NIGHT vs DUST separation and shielded/unshielded duality — the technical custodian. Blockleaders
- **Mike Ward** — listed in user brief as "CEO Shielded Technologies" [unverified — my sources show Barak in that role]. May be an earlier or parallel title; check Thursday.
- **Bob Blessing-Hartley** — listed in user brief as "CTO" [unverified — my sources show Beckmann as CTO].
- **Mauricio Magaldi** (Head of Product) / **Jonathan Sobel** (Architect) / **Lauren Lee** / **Ahmed El-Mahdey** — named in user brief; no quote-level public signal surfaced in this session [unverified — user-provided].
- **Anthony Day** — Host of the **Unshielded** podcast (Midnight's official channel). Tracking his most recent 3–4 episodes is the fastest way to identify the talking points being amplified during hackathon week.

Aliit Fellowship Cohort 0 (midnight.network/blog/introducing-cohort-0-of-the-midnight-aliit-fellowship) — not formal judges but mentor-eligible, embedded in Discord:

- **Tainá (Edda Labs, Brazil)** — *four-time Midnight hackathon competitor, multiple 1st/2nd-place finishes (zk bulletin boards, private voting, battleship, privacy-preserving auctions). Foundation-funded RWA + sustainability projects under her belt.* Single most relevant person to model. Midnight
- **Utkarsh (Webisoft)** — senior systems engineer, built **Web3fast.dev** AI tooling platform for Compact. Midnight
- **Andreas (Indonesia)** — Midnight validator operator, Cardano Ambassador 4 yrs. Midnight

- **Sam (India)** — onboarding 100+ Indian devs. Midnight
- **Elliot (Nigeria)** — built on Statera, FluidTokens, FundAGoal. Midnight
- **Stephanie** — joined Midnight after a personal identity-theft incident; produces tutorials/livestreams. **Her personal narrative arc mirrors the SafePassage motivation** — signal alignment in Discord chat. Midnight
- **Kaleab Abayneh** [unverified — user-listed but not surfaced].

What Midnight *explicitly* says it cares about:

- **"High-potential, idea-stage projects"** — Build Club wants prototype, not finished products. Midnight
- **"Privacy, data protection, or trust in digital systems."** Midnight
- **"Interoperable products that can scale across ecosystems"** — Build Club does **not** require Midnight-exclusive deployment. Midnight
- **"Selective disclosure"** appears in essentially every official paragraph.
- Hoskinson's literal line: **"no one ever got fired for buying Midnight."** Midnight = "IBM-safe," GDPR-compliant. **Avoid framing SafePassage as "untraceable money for victims"** — that triggers exactly the Pressley/Congressional concern in §7. Blockleaders Blockleaders

TACTICAL IMPLICATION FOR SAFEPASSAGE: Write the video and README in Eran Barak's vocabulary: "metadata as attack surface," "selective disclosure," "rational privacy," "the abuser is the threat model." Avoid Zcash-coded language ("anonymous," "untraceable"). Cite Anthony Day's most recent Unshielded episode in Discord. Name-drop Tainá's auction work as inspiration if you build a sealed disbursement.

---

3) BUILD CLUB DEEP DIVE

Confirmed structure (midnight.network/build-club + Summit page):

- **8-week, part-time educational program** for "high-potential, idea-stage projects." (MLH event page says "two-month accelerator" — same thing.) Midnight
- **5 Build Club seats per Summit cycle:** 1 Top Overall, 1 Runner-up in same track, 3 other track winners, 1 community-vote. **Mapping to May 2026 MLH event**: 4 tracks (AI/DeFi/Gaming/Best-Beginner) + Top 2 Overall = ~**6 Build Club invitations** [inference based on Summit pattern + MLH event-page language]. Midnight
- **Participant benefits:** weekly guidance on business/technical/pitch/marketing/roadmap; "suite of tools and resources valued at $100,000"; 1:1 mentorship; concept validation across software dev, business design, regulatory alignment, GTM. Midnight

- **Exit ramp:** week-8 pitch to **Midnight's investor network** → selected projects → **Midnight Accelerator** (deeper technical integration, follow-on funding, GTM). Midnight
- **Interoperability clause:** explicitly does **not** require Midnight-exclusive deployment — "interoperable products that can scale across ecosystems." Midnight

Known Build Club participants (sparse data):

- **Rohan Sidhu — We b0nd** (Yale University Design Studio focus groups) [user-provided; not independently corroborated].
- Aliit Fellowship Cohort 0 members feed the same ecosystem, though Aliit is a *separate* program.

Comparable accelerators (reference patterns):

- **Aleo's $100K Paris Hackathon → Eclipse** (medium.com/@alexandregrondin7/eclipse-redefining-defi-lending-with-privacy-on-aleo) is the closest analog — hackathon winner spinning into a fund-raising entity targeting institutional pilots. Medium
- **StarkWare, Aztec, Aleo, Polygon BUIDL IT, Aave Grants** = 6–12 weeks, mentorship-heavy, demo-day end. Midnight Build Club fits this shape with stronger regulatory emphasis.
- The non-crypto "Build Club" (Annie Liao, Sydney; startupdaily.net) is a different organization — do not confuse.

Implicit Build Club selection criteria:

1. Solo or 2-person teams favored.
2. Concept validation > completed code.
3. Regulatory alignment is in-brief.
4. GTM plausibility — name customers (DV shelters, NNEDV, state crime-victim funds).

TACTICAL IMPLICATION FOR SAFEPASSAGE: Write your README and pitch *to a Build Club application reviewer*, not just to MLH judges. Include a 3-line "Why Build Club" paragraph that hits idea-stage validation, regulatory alignment, and interoperability ("Midnight-native today; selective-disclosure standard portable to Aztec/Aleo tomorrow"). This costs nothing with MLH judges and dramatically raises your Top-2-Overall probability.

---

4) MLH HACKATHON JUDGING MECHANICS

Confirmed (github.com/MLH/mlh-policies/blob/main/standard-hackathon-rules.md, guide.mlh.io, prior midnight-hackathon.devpost.com):

- **Four standard MLH digital judging criteria, weighted equally** (per MLH policies repo): **Technology, Design, Completion, Learning**. Devpost listings for prior MLH×Midnight events displayed **Technology, Originality, Execution** + 1 — sponsor events sometimes substitute "Originality" for "Design" and add a sponsor-specific 4th (typically "Use of Midnight"). Plan for both shapes.
- **What MLH says criteria do NOT include:** code quality, pitch quality, idea novelty per se, problem-fit. **"You are not judged on the quality of your pitch or the quality of your idea — you are judged on what you built."** A working demo with a mediocre pitch *beats* a brilliant pitch with no demo. HackTX 2025
- **Submission format:**
  - **2-minute or less demo video** — required by MLH digital policy. GitHub
  - Must state hackathon name at start: *"Hey I'm Stephen and this is my demo for the Midnight Hackathon."* Midnight Hackathon
  - Submitted via **Devpost** (mandatory). Devpost email MUST match events.mlh.io check-in email. Mismatch = disqualified. Midnight Hackathon
  - **GitHub repo must stay public** post-event or prizes revoked. Midnight Hackathon
  - **Video must be created the weekend of the hackathon.** Midnight Hackathon
  - **One project / one track only.** Midnight Hackathon
- **Judging time per project:** MLH organizer guide recommends **3–4 minutes per project per judge × 3 rounds = ~12 min cumulative judge attention** in science-fair format. **The first 30 seconds of your video matter most.** MLH
- **Sponsor track vs Overall:** sponsor judges (Midnight DevRel + Foundation) decide DeFi track; MLH + sponsor judges together typically decide Top Overall using science-fair format with ⩾3 sightings per project. **Top 2 Overall is typically selected from the four track winners or via a separate finalist round** [inference — pattern but not formally published].
- **AI tools allowed if disclosed.** List Claude/Cursor + Midnight Compact Agent Skill in your submission. Non-disclosure = disqualification. GitHub
- **Originality:** all work during hackathon; pre-existing scaffolds/libraries/Midnight example repos are fine.

TACTICAL IMPLICATION FOR SAFEPASSAGE:

1. The 2-minute video is the highest-leverage artifact. Front-load (a) harm prevented, (b) live transaction, (c) the words "selective disclosure" within the first 45 seconds.
2. Triple-check Devpost↔MLH email match by Friday noon.
3. Don't try to "wow with novelty" — judges are told *not* to weigh idea novelty. Spend time on Completion and Execution.

5) PRIVACY-BLOCKCHAIN HACKATHON WINNING PATTERNS (BROADER)

Aleo — most directly comparable:

- **Eclipse (Aleo Paris, $100K)** — French student team, private DeFi lending with off-chain proof oracle, compliance-without-disclosure pitch. Now scaling toward hedge-fund pilots 2026 (medium.com/@alexandregrondin7/eclipse-redefining-defi-lending-with-privacy-on-aleo). **A *named DeFi primitive* (lending) + *named real-world adopter* (hedge funds) = winning archetype.** Medium Medium
- **Aleo Privacy Virtual Hackathon (May 2025, 100K $ALEO)** — categories: Private Compliance Stablecoins, Verifiable Private States, DeFi, Identity. Weights: Innovation, Technical Impl, UX, Practicality, **zk Proof Usage** (aleoprivatehackathon.devpost.com). Luma Devpost
- **Aleo CodeSprint v4.0 (Aug 2025)** — elimination format, finalists demo on Discord; tracks include Staking, Collateralized Loans, DEX Liquidity, Yield Farming, Dollarization. All Hackathons All Hackathons
- **zkHackathon Thailand (Aleo, Nov 2024)** — half of prizes conditional on **deploying to mainnet and maintaining post-launch** — explicit longevity premium. Devpost

ZK Hack Berlin (June 20–22, 2025) — 5th edition, Berlin Blockchain Week (zkhack.dev/2025/06/26/zk-hack-berlin/):

- Hackers' Choice: **TruthSeeker** (Romario) — privacy-first proof-of-video authenticity. Classic "this couldn't exist on a transparent chain" win. ZK Hack
- Aleo bounty winners: **Mohit (LeoMafia), Gianfranco & Reymo (Kinky Swap), Jordan (Pessimistic ZK Fair Liquidations)**. Note "Fair Liquidations" — privacy-because-positions-are-hidden-until-trigger. ZK Hack
- Irreducible bounties: **Roman (Zerocheck Optimization), Sean & Igor (The Last Checksum)**. ZK Hack
- **Solo/small-team winners are common.**

Broader privacy-blockchain ecosystems (Aztec Network, Polygon zkEVM, ZKVerify, RISC Zero, Mina, 0G, iExec): I did not exhaust web search budget on these specific ecosystems in this session, but pattern-recognition across the Aleo/Midnight/ZK Hack corpus is consistent: **the same winning template** (named primitive + named institutional persona + working demo + compliance/disclosure hook + "this couldn't exist on a transparent chain" framing) reliably appears across all privacy-chain hackathons in 2024-2025 [inference, high-confidence]. Specifically: **Aztec's Noir hackathons** have repeatedly rewarded private payments + identity, **RISC Zero bounties** reward verifiable off-chain compute integrated with on-chain settlement,

Mina's zkApps reward succinctness; none of these fundamentally change the rubric Stephen should optimize for.

Recurring meta-patterns:

1. **"Compliance with privacy" beats "anonymity"** — every winning DeFi project pairs privacy with regulator-friendly disclosure.
2. **Specific institutional persona named in the README.**
3. **The "this couldn't exist on a transparent chain" test** — Eclipse can't run on Aave because position data leaks; TruthSeeker can't run on Ethereum because the camera-attestation pattern leaks the source. **Make this an explicit slide.** Medium
4. **Solo builders win** — TruthSeeker (Romario), Jordan, Mohit, Roman all appear solo/small-team.
5. **Mainnet-week hackathons reward simplicity** — when toolchain is fragile, the prize goes to teams whose contract compiles + deploys cleanly. Complex circuits fail.

TACTICAL IMPLICATION FOR SAFEPASSAGE: Adopt the Eclipse template visually — one-line tagline ("Private emergency disbursements for IPV survivors, auditable for state crime-victim funds"), architecture diagram with off-chain witness + on-chain shielded ledger, a "this couldn't exist on Ethereum because [coercion-vector trace]" slide. The "could-not-exist-on-transparent-chain" claim is rhetorically strongest for SafePassage of any DeFi-track project that will exist this weekend.

---

6) MAINNET-LAUNCH FAILURE MODES

Mainnet went live late March 2026 (coindesk.com/markets/2026/02/12/...; phemex.com/news/article/midnight-network-launches-on-mainnet-70690). Hackathon is **~6–7 weeks post-mainnet** with tooling still stabilizing. CoinDesk

Confirmed known issues:

- **Compact compiler pragma mismatches.** `compact fixup` **refuses to fix a contract whose** `pragma language_version` **differs from the toolchain version**, returning errors like `language version 0.19.0 mismatch` and `compiler version 0.26.0 mismatch` (docs.midnight.network/relnotes/compact-tools/compact-tools-0-3-0). Adjust the pragma manually *first*, then re-run fixup. **Latest documented toolchain: 0.28.0.** Midnight + 2
- **Pragma syntax:** `pragma language_version >= 0.16 && <= 0.25;` is the broadly compatible form (dev.to/midnight-aliit/hands-on-midnight-deep-dive-...). Midnight's official quickstart uses `>= 0.23` (docs.midnight.network/getting-started/hello-world) and `0.22` (docs.midnight.network/getting-started/quickstart). Pick one and pin it. DEV Community + 2

- `disclose()` **wrapper required** for any private value written to public ledger. Forgetting it = #1 compile error.
- `Opaque<"string">` is the supported string type; raw TS strings don't pass.
- **Lace 2.0 stability — released April 28, 2026.** Bugs actively patched within hackathon week:
  - **v2.0.3** fixed "white screen" migration bug + DApp connect failures (lace.io team tweet May 9, 2026 — *5 days before this hackathon*). Crypto News
  - **v2.0.4** added Side-Panel/Tab toggle + auto-lock timer; fixed missing Spanish/Japanese translations (cryptonews.net/news/altcoins/32838242/; kucoin.com/news/flash/cardano-web3-wallet-launches-lace-2-0-update-ahead-of-major-hard-fork). Crypto News
- **Lace Mobile is Android-only**; iOS still under Apple review (lace.io/blog/lace-mobile-is-here-finally). **Do not demo from an iPhone.** Medium
- **Midnight on Lace mobile is not yet supported** — only the Lace 2.0 **browser extension** supports Midnight (lace.io/blog/introducing-lace-2-0-a-new-chapter-begins). Demo from desktop extension only. Lace
- **Proof server requires Docker Desktop running locally** (docs.midnight.network/getting-started/hello-world). Mac M-series users have historically hit Docker Rosetta translation issues with proof servers [inference based on widely-reported Docker/Rosetta patterns; verify Thursday]. Midnight

Midnight Compact Agent Skill (a.k.a. Midnight MCP) — your single most leveraged tool:

- At **forum.midnight.network/t/midnight-compact-agent-skill-compiler-validated-reference-for-ai-assisted-development/1083**.
- Open-source Agent Skill that "teaches AI coding assistants how to write Compact smart contracts for Midnight." **Compiler-validated** — reference is generated against a real compiler so AI doesn't hallucinate Compact syntax. Midnight Network
- Install into Claude/Cursor *before* you start writing.

Web3fast.dev (Utkarsh / Webisoft) is a community-built Compact acceleration tool worth installing as backup.

Common 48-hour failure modes:

- Building the wrong thing first (UI scaffolding hours 0–8, then realize contract doesn't compile at hour 30).
- Local proof-server bringup eating 4–8 hours.
- Demo-time wallet crash from a mid-hackathon Lace auto-update. **Lock Lace to v2.0.4 Thursday, disable auto-update.**

- No fallback "stub" contract — failing to push a working counter contract to testnet by hour 12 leaves zero insurance.
- **Estimated % of teams that fail to deploy a working contract by end of hackathon: ~40–60%** for 48-hr blockchain hackathons on fresh tooling [unverified specific number; reflective of widely-observed pattern at Aleo/Aztec/StarkWare early events].

TACTICAL IMPLICATION FOR SAFEPASSAGE: Pin Compact toolchain Thursday. Pin Lace 2.0.4. Install Midnight Compact Agent Skill into your AI coding tool. Deploy a 10-line "hello world" SafePassage placeholder to testnet by hour 6. Never be in a position where "nothing is deployed" is a possible Sunday outcome.

---

7) SPECIFIC TACTICAL INTEL ON SAFEPASSAGE FEASIBILITY

Regulatory & political landscape — *highly favorable* if handled correctly:

- **Congressional attention is *already on this exact intersection*.** Rep. Ayanna Pressley (MA-07), House Financial Services Committee, **June 5, 2025** hearing transcript (pressley.house.gov/2025/06/06/video-pressley-highlights-how-crypto-blockchain-enables-abuse-in-intimate-partner-violence/; coverage at citizenportal.ai/articles/3701996/...). Pressley: *"We cannot allow blockchain tools to become safe havens for abusers and predators."* Cuts both ways: Ayanna Pressley
  - **In your favor:** Congress has named IPV-crypto as a high-priority gap. SafePassage is the protective use, not the abusive one.
  - **Against you if mis-framed:** "untraceable, anonymous transfers for survivors" sounds exactly like the problem Pressley described. SafePassage must show **selective disclosure to victim-services orgs / court-appointed auditors / state crime-victim compensation programs**, not just secrecy.
- Pressley identified specific abuse modes: hiding $500K BTC during divorce, draining shared crypto wallets, bypassing court freezes. **Cite this transcript in your README** — converts regulatory risk into the policy goal you're solving. CitizenPortal.ai
- **Bank Secrecy Act / AML / FinCEN:** the framing is FinCEN's tolerance for **privacy-preserving compliance** when KYC/AML thresholds are mediated through selective disclosure. Build Club mentors will know this; you just need to acknowledge the constraint exists.

Prior art:

- **Smashboard (India)** — encrypted, blockchain-anchored evidence storage for sexual-violence survivors (mandatedreporter.com/blog/blockchain-technology-is-fighting-abuse-and-exploitation/). Mandated Reporter

- **HeHop (France) — Sandy Beky** — capture data convertible into legal evidence against assailants. Mandated Reporter
- **Seeds token (CoinDesk 2018)** — survivor crowdfunded anonymously via crypto token, redeemed for fiat. CoinDesk also profiles an **anonymous DV-survivor + blockchain developer building a suite of money-management dApps**: *"Being financially stable was the key reason why I was able to leave… Survivors, like other disadvantaged folks, lack wealth-building vehicles."* (coindesk.com/markets/2018/11/10/sexual-assault-survivor-uses-crypto-to-crowdfund-anonymously). CoinDesk
- **DomesticShelters.org cryptocurrency donations, Eve's Place crypto, RTI International DVRR Alameda County pilot** [unverified — user-provided; consistent with the existing crypto-acceptance pattern at orgs like American Red Cross / UNICEF].
- US Patent **12445824** ("System and method for ecosystem encapsulator with emergency response on the blockchain") explicitly names domestic violence among the emergency scenarios for blockchain-anchored transactional records (uspto.gov). uspto

Coercion-vector threat model — academic foundation: The user task brief correctly names the foundational literature. From my own knowledge of this field consistent with related NIH/NCBI work (e.g., ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC9234643/ on IPVAW and coercive control; ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC10594147/ on IPV online help-seeking):

- **Freed et al. CSCW 2017 "Digital Technologies and Intimate Partner Violence"** + **Freed et al. 2018 "A Stalker's Paradise"** established the empirical pattern that abusers: (a) demand passwords, (b) install spyware on shared devices, (c) monitor financial accounts, (d) physically coerce digital actions.
- **Matthews et al. CHI 2017 "Stories from Survivors"** — IPV threat models are fundamentally different from those for activists/whistleblowers because the adversary has physical access.
- **Tanczer et al. (UCL) "Threat Modeling Intimate Partner Violence"** formalized this as HCI threat-modeling discipline.
- **Harris and Woodlock 2019 "Digital Coercive Control"** — the term Stephen should use literally. [These citations are user-asserted and field-consistent; not all independently re-verified in this session.]

Design implications for SafePassage:

- **Coercion-vector = abuser physically present, forcing survivor to open the app.** Required defenses: (a) duress passcode showing decoy state, (b) no app icon / hidden launcher, (c) one-way disbursement (survivor cannot send funds *back* to previously-used wallet, blocking coerced "return the money" flows), (d) time-delayed reversibility window adjudicated by a victim-services org. **This is where Midnight's selective disclosure is**

genuinely load-bearing — auditor can prove the transfer happened to the right person without exposing it to the abuser's surveillance.

- **NNEDV Safety Net** is the canonical industry partner. **No public NNEDV ↔ crypto partnership has been announced as of this search** [unverified] — itself an opportunity: SafePassage could position as the first.

TACTICAL IMPLICATION FOR SAFEPASSAGE: Your single strongest pitch sentence: *"This protocol exists because the Pressley hearing identified a regulatory gap, the IPV-tech literature (Freed, Tanczer, Matthews) identified a threat model standard finance can't accommodate, and Midnight's selective disclosure is the only architecture that satisfies both — privacy from the abuser, auditability for the state crime-victim fund."* That sentence wins DeFi track and gets you Build Club consideration in one beat.

---

8) DEMO PRESENTATION LOGISTICS

Confirmed format:

- **2-minute or less pre-recorded demo video** — canonical MLH digital submission. Live demo is NOT the primary mechanism for online MLH events; judges review videos async.
- Upload to YouTube/Loom/Vimeo (publicly viewable), link from Devpost.
- **Required opening line:** *"Hey I'm Stephen and this is my demo for the Midnight Hackathon."* Missing this has invalidated prior MLH submissions.
- **Video must be created the weekend of the event.**
- **Devpost submission must include:** GitHub link, written description, video link, track selection. Email match with MLH events page mandatory.
- **Q&A:** for digital MLH events Q&A is typically NOT part of judging directly. **Discord office hours** during the event are the de-facto place to interact with judges/mentors — your behavior there is signal.
- **Top 2 Overall** typically determined by sponsor judges reviewing track-winning videos in a finalist round, not by additional live demoing.

Solo-demoer tactics:

1. **First 15 sec: the harm.** Don't open with what you built. Open with the user's situation. ("Sarah is leaving an abusive relationship tonight. Her shared bank account is monitored.")
2. **Next 30 sec: architecture in one diagram**, on-screen ≥10 sec.
3. **Next 45 sec: live transaction demo.** Show shielded ledger + auditor view.
4. **Final 30 sec: institutional vision.** Name a customer; reference Build Club intent ("we want to spend 8 weeks with NNEDV partners refining...").

5. **USB mic** is the highest-ROI hardware for a solo demoer.
6. **Caption the video** — first-pass judges watch with sound off.
7. **YouTube title:** "SafePassage – Midnight Hackathon May 2026 – DeFi Track" (searchable on Discord).

TACTICAL IMPLICATION FOR SAFEPASSAGE: Spend Sunday hours 36–46 on the video specifically. The video is more important than the last 10 hours of code. Record three takes. Watch each one back at 1.5× speed.

---

9) SPONSOR INTELLIGENCE

From the MLH events page (events.mlh.io/events/14061-midnight-hackathon-may-2026):

- **Primary sponsor:** Midnight Network / Shielded Technologies.
- **Hardware prize sponsors by track:**
  - **AI track →** Soundcore by Anker Space Q45 Noise-Cancelling Headphones. Buildclub
  - **DeFi track →** ASUS ZenScreen MB169CK-P Portable USB Monitor. Buildclub
  - **Gaming track →** Logitech MX Master 3S Wireless Mouse. Buildclub
  - **Best Beginner track →** Premium Keychron Mechanical Keyboards. Buildclub
- All winners get **Midnight Swag Bag + Build Club invitation.** Buildclub
- Prior Sep 2025 MLH×Midnight had Anker Soundcore headphones across categories — **Anker is the recurring MLH×Midnight hardware partner.**
- **Build Club invite math May 2026:** 4 track winners + Top 2 Overall = **~6 Build Club slots** [inference].
- Typical adjacent MLH×blockchain sponsors (CockroachDB, Auth0, Standard Library, .Tech Domains, Streamlit) often appear as side prizes — non-Build-Club routes but worth checking the Discord pinned channel Friday.

TACTICAL IMPLICATION FOR SAFEPASSAGE: The DeFi track hardware (ASUS monitor) is irrelevant — your prize is the Build Club seat. **Top 2 Overall competition will most likely come from the AI track**, because privacy + AI is the Midnight team's loudest current narrative (Barak's metadata/AI quotes are now part of their pitch deck). Gaming track tends to lose Overall because gaming privacy stories rarely carry institutional buyer personas. Frame SafePassage as also being "AI-resistant by design" if you can squeeze in one line — it speaks across track judges.

---

10) FORTUNE COOKIE / OPEN-ENDED INTEL

Hoskinson's "four pillars" for Midnight 2026 (confirmed: coinmarketcap.com/cmc-ai/midnight-

network/latest-updates/; mexc.com/news/1029991; kucoin.com/news/insight/ADA/69e2f9c99b8ebc0007cc8411): MEXC KuCoin

1. **Midnight DeFi Kernel** — core private-finance infrastructure. *Your track is named after this pillar*. CoinMarketCap
2. **Passport Program** — identity/access layer (selective disclosure of credentials; zkBadge thread continued). CoinMarketCap
3. **Minotaur** — multi-resource consensus design (2022 IOG whitepaper). CoinMarketCap Coinfomania
4. **Nightstream** — GPU-accelerated ZK proof generation layer (tradingkey.com/…/261653445). Tradingkey

Hoskinson: *"I want the ability to create an account within 60 seconds and have it actually be useful, have it work on your phone, never have to have 24 keywords or manage cryptographic material."* — signals the UX bar he wants personally. Projects that explicitly address onboarding friction resonate. MEXC

"Midnight City" simulation (midnight.city) — launched **Feb 26, 2026**, tests proof generation at scale under real-world-like load (coindesk.com/…/charles-hoskinson-announces-late-march-debut-…). **Tactical use:** reference Midnight City as proof of network readiness in your video — cheap Hoskinson-vocabulary points. Some 2026 commentary frames it as the home for agent-based, subscription-style payments denominated in NIGHT. CoinDesk CoinMarketCap

"Selective disclosure" — the team's North Star phrase. Appears in essentially every official paragraph (Lace blog, Midnight blog, Build Club page, Summit hackathon materials). **Use the literal phrase 2–3 times in your video and README.**

Cardano-ecosystem affinity: Midnight is the "partner chain" (not "sidechain") in 2026 messaging. Lace 2.0 brings Cardano + Bitcoin + Midnight under one wallet. **Connecting SafePassage to a Cardano use case (Cardano-deployed DV non-profit, RealFi micro-lending pattern) earns affinity points** — Hoskinson personally cares. CoinDesk Lace

Aliit Fellowship as future judge pipeline. Cohort 0 not yet judges, but embedded in Discord and explicitly described as the future ambassador layer. **Engaging Tainá, Stephanie, or Elliot in Discord with substantive technical Compact questions is a free positive-signal generator.**

Anthony Day's Unshielded podcast is the highest-value 30-min listen pre-event. Pull two phrases the host uses repeatedly, echo them in the video.

Discord #mlh-hackers / #midnight-hackers channels:

- #1 source for last-minute organizer announcements (judging round shifts, deadline tweaks, time zones).
- Mentors hang out — **ask substantive technical questions there, not generic ones.**

- Last-minute prize bonuses sometimes drop here.
- Judges sometimes preview projects that caught their eye — read in real time during demo round.

Two under-discussed signals:

- Eran Barak's canonical metadata-leakage example: **"frequency of visits to a doctor."** The SafePassage analog: **"frequency of small transfers to a domestic-violence shelter address."** Use this *exact* construction explicitly — same shape as his example.
- Hoskinson's "fairness" one-word Consensus answer: *"no ICO, no privileged investors, just a new model where everyone plays by the same rules."* SafePassage's *fair access* angle (the survivor without crypto experience getting first-class access) plays directly to this. Blockleaders

TACTICAL IMPLICATION FOR SAFEPASSAGE: North-Star vocabulary in priority order — *selective disclosure* (Eran/Fahmi), *rational privacy* (Hoskinson), *metadata as attack surface* (Eran), *real apps, real users, real-world impact* (Fahmi), *fairness* (Hoskinson). Use four of these five in your 2-minute video.

DELIVERABLE-COVERAGE TABLE

#	Deliverable	Covered	Notes
1	Past Midnight hackathon winners	✅	All major events, named winners; Scaffold Midnight + MCP referenced (sect. 1 + 6)
2	Team / likely judges intelligence	✅	Barak, Hoskinson, Syed, Beckmann, Day, Aliit Cohort 0. Ward/Blessing-Hartley/Magaldi/Sobel/Lee/El-Mahdey flagged [unverified]
3	Build Club deep dive	✅	8-week structure, selection logic, slot math, comparators
4	MLH judging mechanics	✅	4 criteria, time budget, sponsor vs overall, AI rules, video rules
5	Privacy-blockchain winning patterns	✅	Aleo + ZK Hack Berlin detailed; Aztec/Polygon/RISC Zero/Mina/0G/iExec covered at pattern-level [inference]
6	Mainnet-launch failure modes	✅	Compact pragma, Lace 2.0.x patches, proof server/Docker, Compact Agent Skill (= Midnight MCP), Web3fast.dev

#	Deliverable	Covered	Notes
7	SafePassage feasibility	✅	Pressley hearing, Smashboard, HeHop, Seeds, USPTO patent, academic threat model
8	Demo presentation logistics	✅	Video format, Devpost flow, opening line, captioning
9	Sponsor intelligence	✅	Hardware-per-track, Build Club math, Anker partnership
10	Fortune cookie	✅	4 pillars, Midnight City, selective-disclosure, Cardano affinity, Aliit, Unshielded, Discord

---

TOP 10 ACTIONS FOR STEPHEN BEFORE FRIDAY MAY 15, 2026 NOON ET

Ranked by ROI; each specific and executable.

1. Pin your toolchain by Thursday 6pm ET. Install **Compact toolchain 0.26.0 or 0.28.0** (one, not both), pin `pragma language_version` to a single value (e.g., `>= 0.22`), verify `compact compile` runs end-to-end on a counter contract. Disable Lace auto-update; confirm Lace 2.0.4 specifically (the May 9, 2026 patched version). Confirm Docker Desktop runs the Midnight proof server without Rosetta errors on Mac. *Eliminates the most common 48-hr blockchain-hackathon failure mode.*

2. Install the Midnight Compact Agent Skill (a.k.a. Midnight MCP) into your AI coding tool. Pull from forum.midnight.network/t/midnight-compact-agent-skill-compiler-validated-reference-for-ai-assisted-development/1083. Load before you start coding. Backup: Web3fast.dev (Utkarsh/Webisoft).

3. Triple-check identity continuity: Devpost email = events.mlh.io email = GitHub email. Create your Devpost submission draft Thursday — empty but registered for the **DeFi track**. Test that you can edit it. MLH disqualifies on email mismatch.

4. Read the Eran Barak Cointelegraph interview + the Blockleaders Consensus 2025 panel writeup + listen to one recent Unshielded podcast episode. Extract 4–5 verbatim phrases into `vocab.md`. Aim to use *selective disclosure*, *rational privacy*, *metadata as attack surface*, and one Anthony Day phrase in your video.

5. Write your README.md and 90-second demo script Friday morning, before code. Highest-ROI pre-hackathon hour: draft the README's "Why SafePassage on Midnight" paragraph and the demo's opening 15 seconds. Technical work fills around the narrative, not vice versa.

6. Deploy a stub contract to Midnight testnet/preview by hour 6 of the hackathon. A 10-line "SafePassage stub: emergency disbursement counter" deployed by Friday late-evening guarantees something to demo Sunday. Iterate from a working baseline, never from zero.

7. Pre-write your Build Club application paragraph and embed it in the README. 3 lines covering: idea-stage validation, regulatory alignment (cite **Pressley June 2025 hearing**), interoperability ("Midnight-native today; selective-disclosure standard portable tomorrow"). Build Club selection is partly downstream of MLH ranking — this paragraph helps both audiences.

8. Pre-record audio for your demo voiceover Friday afternoon (script + USB mic). You'll be exhausted Sunday — recording narration while clear-headed Friday, then overlaying onto demo screen-capture Sunday, is the solo-builder pro move. Caption file done Saturday night.

9. Pre-join Midnight Discord + MLH Discord + #midnight-hackers / #mlh-hackers Thursday. Introduce yourself with one substantive sentence: *"Solo CS sophomore, building privacy-preserving disbursement for IPV survivors on Midnight DeFi track — anyone built shielded one-way transfer constraints in Compact?"* Generates name recognition with mentors *before* chaos starts. Optionally engage Tainá / Stephanie — both have personal alignment with SafePassage's motivation.

10. Build your coercion-vector defense slide as a separate single-page artifact. One diagram: abuser physically present → survivor opens app → duress passcode path vs. real path → on Midnight, disbursement is shielded from abuser's surveillance but auditable by state crime-victim fund. This slide is your Top-2-Overall argument in one image. Embed at the **1:00 mark** of the demo video.

End of reconnaissance. Compass setting: build the simplest contract that compiles, embed the harm and the auditor in 90 seconds, speak Midnight's vocabulary literally, and demo from a wallet that you have not auto-updated since Thursday.